Challenges faced by migrant workers in India

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Migrant workers in India face **layered challenges**: insecure livelihoods, weak social protection, poor access to healthcare, housing and sanitation deficits, language and documentation barriers, discrimination, and heightened mental-health stress—problems that became especially severe during COVID-19 but are also structural, not temporary. [1] [3] [4] [6] [7] [8] [34] [35] [36] [37]

Main challenges

Challenge area	What it looks like in India	Why it matters
Livelihood insecurity and informality	Migrant workers are concentrated in informal, precarious jobs with low wages, job insecurity, and weak labour rights; lockdowns made many unable to sustain themselves. [1] [10] [11] [35] [38] [39] [40] [41]	This leaves workers vulnerable to sudden income loss, exploitation, and exclusion from formal protections. [1] [11] [38] [42]
Lack of social security and welfare access	Workers often lack access to schemes because of mobility, missing documents, low digital literacy, regional policy differences, and weak awareness; even when schemes exist, implementation is patchy. [1] [6] [29] [37] [42] [43] [44] [45]	Limited portability of entitlements means migrants can be excluded from relief precisely when they need it most. [1] [9] [46] [47]
Healthcare barriers	Common barriers include cost, language, discrimination, lack of documentation, poor knowledge of available services, and weak portability of benefits; migrants also face limited access to preventive and continuous care. [1] [3] [19] [46] [48] [49] [50] [51] [52] [53] [54]	These barriers delay treatment and worsen health risks, especially for chronic illness, maternal health, and mental health. [1] [18] [21] [46] [55] [56] [57]
Poor housing, sanitation, and living conditions	Migrants are described as living in makeshift, overcrowded, or insecure accommodation with inadequate sanitation and water. [1] [3] [4] [10] [52] [58] [59]	These conditions increase disease exposure and reduce dignity and safety. [1] [3] [58] [59]
Mobility and displacement crises	During the lockdown, many workers were stranded, forced into reverse migration, or walked long distances home, sometimes without food or shelter. [1] [4] [6] [7] [8] [10] [17] [47]	Movement restrictions turned migration into a survival crisis and exposed gaps in emergency planning. [1] [6] [8] [47]

Challenge area	What it looks like in India	Why it matters
Discrimination, stigma, and exclusion	Migrants report social exclusion, unequal treatment, and bureaucratic obstacles; some studies also note alienation, dependency on brokers/employers, and rights denial. [1] [5] [26] [27] [37] [40] [48] [49] [60]	Discrimination compounds economic hardship and makes rights harder to claim in practice. [1] [5] [37] [42]
Mental-health strain	Anxiety, stress, panic, depression, and broader psychological distress are reported, driven by insecurity, discrimination, poor living conditions, and uncertainty about work and family. [1] [7] [50] [55] [56] [57] [61]	Mental-health harm is a major secondary consequence of precarious migration and crisis exposure. [1] [7] [55] [57]
Gendered vulnerability	Women migrants face additional burdens from discrimination, violence, caregiving demands, livelihood loss, and poorer access to health services. [1] [25] [30] [32] [55] [58] [62] [63]	The same structural problems hit women harder and in more ways. [1] [25] [55] [58]

Bottom line

The evidence points to a **structural vulnerability problem**: migrant workers in India are not challenged by one issue alone, but by the combination of informal work, weak portability of rights, poor services, and social exclusion, which together turn migration into a high-risk survival strategy rather than a secure route to opportunity. [1] [8] [11] [42] [59] [64] [65]

Confidence level: **High** — multiple independent sources align on the same core challenges, with especially strong convergence on informality, welfare gaps, healthcare barriers, and pandemic-era displacement. [1] [3] [6] [7] [8] [37] [46] [47]

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